

Theatre Production, Stage Management & Festival Management Experience

My journey in theatre and festival management began from childhood, having been consistently exposed to theatre practices, performance environments, and cultural events from an early age. After discontinuing my studies following 12th grade, I explored a few odd jobs but soon realized they were not aligned with my interests or long-term aspirations. This led me to pursue theatre professionally and relocate from Mysore to Bangalore in order to immerse myself fully in the performing arts industry.

Although I initially started as an actor, I consciously stepped away from acting to develop a stronger technical and operational understanding of theatre production. I believed that building a sustainable career in the performing arts required technical and managerial expertise beyond performance alone. This decision led me into backstage operations, where I began working extensively with stage lighting, sound operation, stage management, production logistics, and rehearsal coordination.

I began my professional career as a freelance stage manager before joining the in-house repertory team at Ranga Shankara. During my time there, I production managed and stage managed over seven theatre productions, collectively performing more than 200 shows. My responsibilities extended across the complete lifecycle of a production — from preparing rehearsal spaces for actors to maintaining costumes and props, coordinating stage setups, preserving and transporting set materials, preparing and interpreting technical riders, and ensuring productions could efficiently tour across different cities and venues.

Touring productions taught me the importance of designing sets and technical systems that were modular, durable, and transportable across the country. The role of a stage manager, in my experience, extends far beyond backstage cue calling. It involves coordinating departments, managing logistics, maintaining production assets, facilitating communication between creative and technical teams, and ensuring the smooth functioning of every operational aspect of a live performance.

Alongside repertory work, I also became deeply involved in festival management at Ranga Shankara. The venue regularly hosted major theatre festivals throughout the year, including the AHA! International Theatre Festival for Children, annual national theatre festivals, and youth theatre festivals. As part of the repertory and production team, I contributed to organizing and managing these festivals, gaining exposure to artist coordination, scheduling, venue operations, hospitality, technical planning, audience management, and festival logistics.

This experience helped me recognize festival management as an independent and highly specialized field within the cultural sector. It broadened my understanding of how festivals function not only as artistic platforms but also as large-scale collaborative systems involving programming, production, communication, infrastructure, and public engagement.

I later moved to Mumbai and joined QTP Entertainment Private Limited as a stage manager. During my time there, I managed five in-house theatre productions and toured extensively across the country. Working with both Ranga Shankara and QTP gave me significant experience in repertory theatre, touring productions, venue adaptation, technical execution, and live event management across diverse performance spaces.

QTP Entertainment was also the organizing company behind Thespo, one of India's leading youth theatre festivals. While still under the age of 25, I worked as a coordinator for the 20th edition of Thespo in 2020. This role gave me deeper exposure to youth arts programming, festival coordination, artist management, scheduling, and large-scale event operations.

In addition to theatre festivals, QTP also organizes Tata Literature Live! The Mumbai LitFest at NCPA Mumbai. I worked on the festival for two consecutive years, in 2018 and 2019, contributing to the management of multidisciplinary cultural events involving authors, performers, audiences, sponsors, venue teams, and technical crews.

In 2019, I was selected for British Council's residency program, Festivals of the Future. I was among the youngest festival managers in the country to be selected for the residency. The program focused on understanding the social and cultural relevance of festivals, the importance of festival intellectual property (IP), the future of cultural programming, and the frameworks required to conceptualize, organize, and sustain independent festivals. The residency also provided insights into programming philosophy, audience engagement, cultural infrastructure, collaboration models, and long-term festival planning.

Beyond conventional theatre and festival management, my professional experiences have also included working in alternative performance environments and interdisciplinary art spaces. Through these experiences, I developed practical knowledge in maintaining performance infrastructure, handling outdoor and site-responsive performance challenges, coordinating technical systems under varying environmental conditions, and understanding the relationship between architecture, technology, and live performance.

Over the course of my career, I have been involved in more than 350 live performances and have stage managed over 20 productions. My work spans theatre production, touring logistics, repertory operations, technical management, cultural festival coordination, artist liaison, and interdisciplinary live event execution. Collectively, these experiences have shaped my understanding of performance not only as an artistic practice, but also as a complex system of coordination, engineering, logistics, collaboration, and audience engagement.